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Chapte#01

INTRODUCTION TO THE RELIGION

What constitutes religion, and how is it defined across different contexts? How do individuals from diverse intellectual traditions, cultural regions, and religious backgrounds interpret its meaning and purpose? Furthermore, when, why, and how did religion originate? What motivates individuals to adhere to religious beliefs and practices? Why has religion remained a significant aspect of human society? This inquiry seeks to explore these and related questions through a structured and analytical approach.

Etymology:

Religion, derived from old French word "**Religiun**" means "Respect for what is sacred" and Latin word "**Religionem**" means "**Reverence for the gods**".

Modern Sense: "Recognition of, and obedience to a higher unseen power". Words "Creed", "Cult" and "Faith" are used as synonyms.

In Urdu, the word "**Mazhab** مذهب" which is originally an Arabic word means "A way to go", "A path to walk", "A style", "A method" etc.

In Arabic, the word "Deen دين" is also used to describe a religion which literally means "Retaliation", "Recompense", "Requital", "Commandment", & "Judgment" etc., for example, Qur'an says " مَالِكِ يَوْمِ الدِّينِ . . . The Master of the Day of Judgment".

Word Religion in holy Qur'an:

The most appropriate of the above mentioned Arabic words in the sense of religion, is "Deen". Although, Qur'an uses some other words as well in this sense like " مِلَّةٌ ... Millah", " طَّيْرًا ... Siraat", " مِنْهَاجٌ ... Minhaaj", & " شِرْعَةٌ ... Shir'ah", but the word preferred and used most often in the divine guidance i.e. Qur'an and Hadith, it is "Deen دين" as it indicates to the requital and the recompense of the deeds in after life. The word "Mazhab مذهب" has not been used anywhere in divine scripture in the sense of religion as it does not express the exact sense of religion except in Urdu, instead, it is used in Arabic for "Point of view" & "School of thought".

Definitions & Concepts:

Religion has been interpreted in diverse ways by individuals across different regions, historical periods, and intellectual traditions. The following presents a selection of

perspectives from Western scholars and philosophers, offering a broader and more nuanced understanding of the concept of religion.

Edward Burnett Tylor

1832-1917 (defines in his book "Primitive Culture") "The belief in spiritual being"

David Emile Durkheim

1858-1917 (writes in his book "The Elementary Forms of the Religious Life")

"Unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things"

William James 1842-1910

(Describes in his book "The Varieties of Religious Experiences") "The feelings, acts and experiences of individual men in their solitude, whatever they may consider the divine."

The crux of the western ideas is that the Religion to them is "A relationship to sacred & spiritual things, feelings in solitude & experiences of individuals."

Divine Perspective: (Eastern Perspective)

"Religion is a complete code of life set and sent down by the Creator, the Lord (God) through His messengers from time to time to guide His slaves (Mankind & Jinn) to the success in life and afterlife".

Analysis:

An analysis of these various perspectives reveals several key observations. Notably, many Western scholars tend to conceptualize religion primarily as a matter of thought or belief, often minimizing its practical dimensions. This theoretical orientation is reflected in broader Western societal attitudes, where religion is frequently viewed as a private affair, and its involvement in public life—particularly in political and economic institutions—is often resisted. This individualistic interpretation of religion, grounded in the diversity of personal beliefs and spiritual orientations, has become increasingly pronounced in the modern Western context.

In contrast, from a theistic or divine perspective—particularly within the Islamic tradition—religion is inherently practical and comprehensive in scope. It functions not merely as a system of belief but as a complete way of life, with approximately 90% of its teachings centered on practice. Furthermore, religion in this context is understood as a

collective and socially integrated phenomenon, rather than solely a personal matter. This collective dimension underscores the notion that individual and communal success in worldly life is deeply interconnected.

Need for Religion:

Religion is an essential need of mankind as it gives meanings to the essence of life, creates objective of existence and establishes the core of mankind. This conversation requires further elaboration on these aspects.

Demand of Nature:

This is mentionable that liberty and freedom have ever been fascinated and desired for human beings and the fact is that man, on account of his natural desire, prefers liberation and emancipation over all kinds of confinements and limitations which are the core of the religion, besides, on ground reality demonstrates that almost 80-85 % of the world population is affiliated to some religion preferring restrictions and confinement set by the religion over emancipation and freedom which is astonishing for man himself. This enigma is uncomplicated to solve.

In fact, association with some religion is the demand of the innate human nature man has been created with. Nature refers to an essential feature or characteristic of something by which that particular object is recognized and known. In case, if this feature is removed, that particular object remains not the same object any more. For instance, water is recognized and known for its liquidity and flow, if this feature is removed, it might be called as ice but not water any more.

In the same way, man has been created with a proviso to be bound to believe in some unseen super natural power. No matter if man recognizes him or not, because it is experienced more than once and proved that one decides and determines for some task and struggles hard to achieve the goal, one eventually fails despite all his determinations. Besides, suffering from undesired diseases, mishaps, demises and disasters demonstrate even compel man to believe in some other contradictive powerful being existing as dominant and more influential than man himself. Man, on account of his nature, is frightened that this power may cause to harm or destruct him in case if gets angry with man. As an end result, man yields to that power to secure himself from any expected or

unexpected failure and mischief and to collect maximum benefits and advantages. It is thus the religion takes birth and it is only the belief in God which can give security to the self and mind, peace to the soul, meaning to the individual and the satisfaction to the human nature.

The Innate Human Nature:

The word "Innate" refers to build in essential human features. Man has been created with an innate nature that compels him to believe in an unseen super natural power as God. Qur'an reveals in Surah Al-A'raf (172) about an incident that occurred in Heaven before Adam (AS) was sent down to earth which is identified as "The Initial Covenant". As per the details described by the Holy Prophet (PBUH), Allah, the Exalted, created all of the human souls from Adam (AS) and presented Himself to them and questioned them, "Am I not your Lord?" They all replied, "Why not" which means they all agreed upon it. This covenant has been set as the innate nature of the human beings by Almighty Allah. This is the nature termed as "Fitrah" in Qur'an and everyone takes birth with same "Fitrah" that leads to the acceptance of the Ultimate Reality "God".

Craves of Mind for the Knowledge of Essential Facts:

The human need for a creed primarily derives from men crave to know himself and the universe around him. The need to find answers has always occupied the concern of human philosophies without reaching the definite solutions. Since their creation, people have had the nagging questions "From where?", "To where?" and "why?" They are sometimes distracted by the demands of daily life, but they one-day return to these eternal questions. Man wonders: from where did I and this immeasurable universe come? Did I come into existence on my own or is there a creator who brought me to existence? Who is he? How am I related to him? What about this vast land, sky, animal, vegetable, mineral, planets and stars? Did they come into existence on their own or is there some sovereign creator? What is after this life? What is after death? Where do we go after the short journey on this planet Earth? Does the story of life from birth to death have nothing beyond that? Do the virtuous who sacrifice their lives for good and truth meet the same end as the wicked and villainous who sacrifice others for their own desires and pleasure? Does life culminate only in death? Or is there some other life after death in which the virtuous are rewarded

and the villainous are punished? And why was mankind brought into existence? Why were people endowed with mind, wisdom, knowledge and volition which distinguish them from all animals? Why does everything in heaven and on earth seem to be in his service? Is there a purpose to his existence? Does he have a mission in life? Or was he brought into existence only to eat as animals do and then expire as animals do? If there is a purpose to existence, what is it? How can this purpose be realized?

These questions have haunted man in every age and demanded answers that satisfy the intellect and soothe the heart. Answers like that are only found in religion or in a pure religious belief. It is religion that primarily teaches man that he came into existence neither by chance nor on his own but he was created by a great Creator Who is his God, That God made man, fashioned him perfectly, gave him due proportion, breathed soul into him, endowed him with hearing, eyesight, mind and heart and granted him all sorts of blessings starting as an embryo in a mother's womb.

History & Background:

Through the history of religions, we come to know that religion has ever been the essential part of human life in every society. The Greek historian Plutarch (46-120 AD) writes, "In history, I have found cities without forts, cities without palaces, cities without schools, but never have I found cities without places of worship". For history of religion, we find archaeological evidences as well; likewise tablets of law by Hammurabi (2300 BC), a king of Babylon lived in Nineveh, the capital of Babylon, almost in the age of Ibrahim (AS). These tablets describe the laws containing some clauses derived from the divine teachings. Moreover, the ancient cemeteries like tombs & pyramids provide the big evidence for religion, because, burial itself, is the teaching of religion taught to mankind through the crows as per the revelation of Qur'an.

But, when and how did it start actually, history is silent and provides no definite answer. But, the divine scriptures like Qur'an & Bible reveal it well that the religion started with the very first person on this earth named Adam (AS).

Universal Features of Religions:

A large number of religions existing in the world are having a massive variety of thoughts and teachings, but some fundamental features are considered as universal and common between all of them, these are following....

- 1- **Faith & Beliefs:** All of the existing religions have the teachings consisting of thoughts called as beliefs. Although, these beliefs vary religion to religion in details, but are common being a theoretical part.
- 2- **Rituals & Customs:** All the religions hold some practical rituals being followed by the followers which later become the identification of that particular religion. This is the second feature common between all of the religions whether they are revealed or non-revealed. But, likewise beliefs, these rituals also vary religion to religion.
- 3- **Ethics & Morality:** All of the religions form their own concepts of good & evil and the curbs of ethical and moral values derived from their own thoughts and rituals. Although, some of the moral values are universal like speaking truth, not telling a lie and not killing the innocent one, but some may vary in various religions. This is very much possible that one value might be considered good in one religion but might not be in the other one.

Religion & Human life:

There is no second opinion in the fact that religion has ever been very influential and put a great impact on humanity, their personal as well as their collective life. Man, being follower of a religion, lives a satisfactory life as he thinks that he has established an awesome relationship with the sacred super natural power that is dominant and holding the authority to beneficate or destruct the human life. Besides, man needs psychological peace and spiritual strength occasionally and also needs a mighty and unfailing supporter at times of hardship and crisis. This is religion that holds man's life, hope and courage, when a person loses something or someone he loves, or fails to achieve something, or is stricken

by misfortune and illness. The religious faith provides him support, strength, hope, condolence and patience.

Religion also affects the collective life of mankind. In fact, the societies are always established on the basis of religion and form their own civilizations and cultures. All the world's great civilizations are known by their religion like the Buddha civilization, the Hindu culture and civilization and the Muslim civilization are named after their religions. Moreover, the religion controls and governs the relationships between society members and makes every member observe his limits, refrain from trespassing the rights of others and not to overlook the welfare of the community for personal immediate gains.

Classification of Religions:

There are almost nine thousand religions including the tribal religions existing in the world. These religions have been classified into two major categories, Revealed & Non-revealed. Revealed refers to the claim by the followers in order to have some divine scripture for human guidance. Judaism, Christianity and Islam are considered as the revealed religions. Rest of the religions have been declared as non-revealed religions as they do not claim to have the divine scripture despite they have some sacred and holy books.

Theological Ideas:

The human search for meaning and transcendence has led to the development of a wide spectrum of theological and philosophical perspectives. These perspectives vary in their understanding of the divine, the cosmos, and the relationship between the two. The following outlines six major viewpoints regarding the existence and nature of God and the universe.

Atheism

Atheism is the doctrinal or philosophical position that denies the existence of God or any divine being. It often posits that the universe is self-existent and not contingent upon any supernatural entity for its origin or sustenance. Atheism ranges from explicit rejection of deities (strong atheism) to mere absence of belief in any god (weak atheism) (Martin,

2007). Contemporary atheists often rely on naturalistic explanations of the universe and human existence, favoring empirical evidence over metaphysical speculation.

Reference:

Martin, M. (2007). **The Cambridge Companion to Atheism**. Cambridge University Press.

Agnosticism

Agnosticism is characterized by a position of uncertainty or non-commitment regarding the existence or non-existence of God. Agnostics maintain that the question of divine existence is inherently unknowable or currently unknown, thus refraining from definitive belief or disbelief. The term was first coined by Thomas Huxley in the 19th century to describe his epistemological stance on metaphysical matters (Thrower, 1980).

Reference:

Thrower, J. (1980). **The Alternative Tradition: A Study of Unbelief in the Ancient World**. Mouton Publishers.

Deism

Deism affirms the existence of a Creator who initiated the universe but denies divine revelation and the ongoing intervention of God in worldly affairs. Deists argue that reason and observation of the natural world are sufficient to discern the existence of a supreme being, without reliance on sacred texts or institutional religion. This view was prevalent among Enlightenment thinkers such as Voltaire and Thomas Jefferson (Israel, 2001).

Reference:

Israel, J. (2001). **Radical Enlightenment: Philosophy and the Making of Modernity 1650–1750**. Oxford University Press.

Pantheism

Pantheism is the belief that God and the universe are identical, asserting that the divine is immanent in all aspects of the natural world. Rather than viewing God as a

personal, transcendent being, pantheists equate divinity with the laws of nature and the cosmos itself. This worldview is found in various philosophical and religious traditions, including certain strands of Hinduism and the writings of Baruch Spinoza (Nadler, 2006).

Reference:

Nadler, S. (2006). **Spinoza's Ethics: An Introduction**. Cambridge University Press.

Monotheism

Monotheism is the belief in the existence of a single, all-powerful, and transcendent God. This worldview forms the theological foundation of the Abrahamic religions—Judaism, Christianity, and Islam—all of which emphasize a personal deity who is both the creator and sustainer of the universe. Monotheism posits that divine revelation is accessible through sacred scriptures and prophetic traditions (Armstrong, 1993).

Reference:

Armstrong, K. (1993). **A History of God: The 4,000-Year Quest of Judaism, Christianity and Islam**. Ballantine Books.

Polytheism

Polytheism denotes belief in multiple deities, each typically associated with specific aspects of nature, human life, or cosmic functions. This system was dominant in ancient civilizations such as Greece, Rome, and Egypt, where gods and goddesses governed various realms like war, love, the sea, and the harvest. Polytheistic traditions often allow for fluid worship and integration of local deities (Burkert, 1985).

Reference:

Burkert, W. (1985). **Greek Religion: Archaic and Classical**. Harvard University Press